

Hook, line and sinker

We love our technology, don't we? I mean we really, really love it to the point of insanity... at times. This month, I was a little taken aback to read about Indonesians trampling over one another to get their hands on the new BlackBerry 9790. This was not because the vendor was offering the 9790 for a mere 4.7 million Indonesian Rupiah, but because he used the oldest trick in the book – offer the first thousand pieces for a 50 per cent discount. That's a saving of about 2.35 million Rupiah (or a little over 11,000 of our Rupees).

Now I'm more used to reading about news stories about long queues and all-night vigils for technology – games, products, whatever – from the West. I never expected Indonesians to go that berserk over a new phone model. Perhaps they're even crazier bargain hunters than us Indians; who knows. Sadly, hundreds were injured in the melee, and of course many phones were sold... What was the major problem? Authorities, obviously not used to such craziness, mistakenly placed the people who had arrived the previous night behind those that arrived early morning, and scuffles broke out.

Anyway, that's Indonesia, where people literally pay in millions for phones... that would never happen here, right? I'm not so sure anymore! The same day all the craziness unfolded in Indonesia, and people rushed to save millions of Rupiahs, quite a few Indians were awake at midnight, and outside Aircel and Airtel shops, itching to spend thousands of Rupees, looking to buy an iPhone 4S.

Obviously Apple phones in India are popular, and you would expect quite a few people to put in orders for the new iPhone, and all the hype around Siri, Apple's new natural language interface. Were there discounts in the offing, as in Indonesia? Not at all. This is a premium product being sold at a premium price...

So, in a country where the most common question about cars is, "*Mileage kitna deti hai?*", and everyone from old aunties to little kids are used to bargaining with the local trader for everything, there was actually a line (regardless of how small or big), for a rather expensive product? Actually, let me rephrase that... I said "rather expensive", I really meant "ridiculously overpriced" – the phones cost Rs. 44,500, Rs. 50,900 and 57,500 for the 16GB, 32GB and 64GB models respectively!

Of course the numbers are small here,

and there's no pushing and shoving involved, because they're expensive models – or as one witty person put it on Facebook, "About half a Tata Nano!". And yes, there's a marketing gimmick thrown in about recovering half the cost in 2 years because of plan discounts, and the likes, but it's still pretty obvious that only a minority (rich, or fanatical), can afford to buy it. However, with over a billion people, this number isn't as small as you and I would like to believe. Thanks to the sheer size of our population and increasingly disposable income, a lot of us are looking to spend a little more than we really *should*.

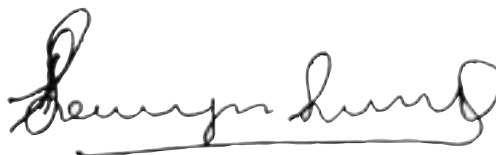
I'm no different, I have to admit. I've bought guitar equipment that I cannot really afford, and a speaker system that isn't officially available in India, and thus costs more than double than the US price. Why? Because there are just some things you like and want, no matter what. Of course, I justify this by telling myself that they are purchases that will last a lifetime – I'm not going to be buying new guitar rigs and speakers for at least the better part of a decade. "Hey, be thankful you're not addicted to new phones!" I tell myself.

So what is it about technology that has us stretching our budgets so easily? How do companies get us to stay addicted to their offerings?

Consumerism, geeks inheriting the earth, or other reasons I've written about in this space before, does it really matter? We've got credit cards, and products drool-worthy enough to make us want to use them.

Plus, the very nature of technology is to renew and refresh, to throw up excitingly new things to fiddle with and try out. Everything is faster today than it was yesterday, everything is more seamlessly connected than last year, and of course, everything is more expensive as well. Of course, salaries are going up, and likewise our expectations. As long as we don't go the sub-prime way, we ought to be fine... or is that just another case of justifying the need to scratch that technology buying itch?

Whatever the case, we've been captured, hook, line and sinker, and we're not complaining. Are we? 



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